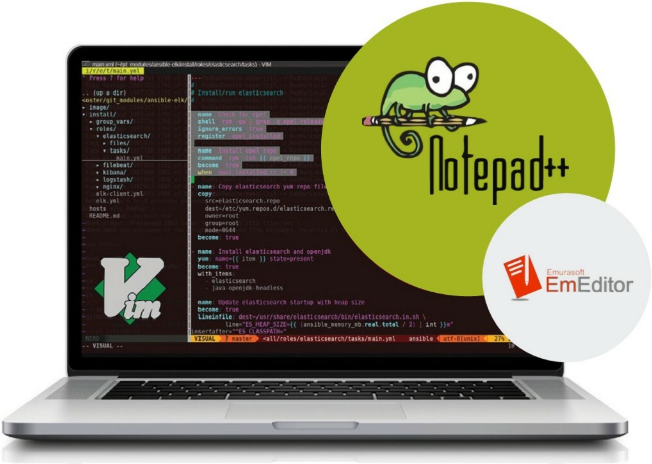
Handling Large Files Using Open Source Tools

Handling large log files is problematic. Systems administrators must be able to open them to view and act upon the vital information they contain. Text editors are the best option for this task. Here is a review of a selection of these editors for our readers.



In almost every project we work on, we need to deal with files. Consider the following scenarios:

- As a systems administrator, you need to deal with large system log files every day (in gigabytes), which are very difficult to handle.
- As a developer, you may have to deal with huge application log files or application source code files.
- As a tester, you may have to deal with the large-sized data files generated as the output of some process, and need to validate a particular attribute present in those files.

There may be various other scenarios as well but, generally, all these data and log files are text files. The difference between a log file, a text file and a data file is that a log file is generated automatically to keep track of some specific application, a text file is created by the user in a word processor, and a data file stores data pertaining to a specific application for later use. Data files can be stored as text files or as binary files, and are particularly helpful when debugging a program.

The need to handle large files carefully

The files generated in the situations mentioned earlier could be of any size, format or encoding. Besides, they may or may not contain the text in specific formats, such as comma-separated values (CSV), log data files (LDF) and master data files (MDF). These large text files may also vary with respect to the lines they have or the reason they need to be opened for. For example, the event log files for some